



Batting masterclass: (Clockwise from left) Suné Luus scored a defiant 109 in the second innings. Marizanne Kapp was steadfast in her 141-ball 74. SA captain Laura Wolvaardt led from the front with a solid 122. India captain Harmanpreet Kaur with the trophy. Smriti Mandhana calls on the Chepauk crowd to cheer louder. PICS: B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

challenges the format poses and its coveted reputation as the game's purest format.

Indian off-spinner Sneha Rana went a step further in asking for more games within the Test fold in a series.

"We should have more Tests and it shouldn't just be the one, there should be two!" she delightedly told reporters.

But calls like that need Tests to be given greater context, first within the series itself and then internationally. The latter is a challenge when there are only four nations actively pursuing the format.

India had the opportunity to go the women's Ashes way and make its home multiformat series adhere to a cumulative points system, where every fixture gets certain points. The winner is the one with the most points at the end of the full tour. Even after its steamrolling of England and Australia in December, India opted not to go that way when South Africa came visiting, despite the latter having stark structural weaknesses compared to the other two.

In such a scenario, much comes down to individual brilliance and even milestones for a large part of the game. Take Shafali Verma's 200,

for instance, which was the headline on day one. A 20-year-old almost going past Indian legend Mithali Raj's Test top score — it was a record the nation was waiting to see with bated breath, but the youngster fell short. Her innings, alongside Smriti Mandhana's fluent 149, gave India the cushion it needed to stay confident no matter how much the Proteas fought until the final session of the last day.

When India eventually sealed the win with well over an hour's play left in the day, the scoresheet of that remarkable Protean second innings made its way around the Chennai Press Box.

A bunch of reporters on duty signed the sheet with messages commending the visitors' efforts.

As Wolvaardt came to speak to the press, she was given the envelope with tributes from the press. "I'm going to frame this," she said.

Heading into the final day, batting coach Baakier Abrahams spoke about the team needing positive frames of reference in this format, particularly when it has little to no red-ball roots in the current system.

"There were some signs we showed of our resilience when we were under pressure and those are

things we want to build on going forward. So if there's going to be more Tests for women, we now have positive reference points to build on and we'll only get better and the level of competition will get better and women's Test cricket will benefit," he said, foreshadowing a spirited batting show that saw SA drag the game to the very end.

This Protean effort must take pride of place in the nation's batting showcase alongside Jacques Kallis, Hansie Cronje, and Adam Bacher's efforts against Australia in 1997 in Melbourne, Faf du Plessis and AB de Villiers' effort against Australia in a drawn Test in Adelaide in 2012, and Kapp's match-saving exploits with the bat against England in Taunton. It didn't bring a win, but it helped the nation remember how to defy the despair of looming defeat and fight till the very end.

With the Proteas set to don the whites again, this time at home against England, it could just be the 'why' that carries them to glory.

The case file for more multi-day red-ball games just got another incredible addition from action at the Chepauk.

One hopes the powers that be, national and international, pick up the pages and read.